



Bhadana, two BJP MLAs, who were expelled from the party. Subsequently, Raje granted the Gurjars some immediate benefits to pacify them, including employment for family members, compensation for those killed and injured in the 2007 agitation, withdrawal of cases against those accused of violence and destruction of public property, the release of Rs 282 crore for the development of the most backward areas with a Gurjar majority and, most crucially, a recommendation to the Centre to provide for 4 to 6 per cent reservation quota for Gurjars like those for nomadic tribes, a classification which fell short of inclusion in the official ST status and has no precedence.

Raje could not recommend ST status because she had set up the Justice Jas Raj Chopra committee, helped by renowned social scholar Yogesh Atal, to look into the Gurjars' main demand of an ST status. The committee was of the view that the

six criteria fixed in the Constitution for determining the status were faulty and had become obsolete as they did not consider local complexities. It had therefore concluded that it was not possible to recommend ST status for Gujarats under the existing guidelines. However, it did state that under the draft of a new tribal policy currently being debated by the Centre, the Gurjars were likely to be included in the ST category and recommended a slew of economic measures for the uplift of the community's poorest section. For the Gurjars, however, the only portion of the report that mattered was that the ST status was to be denied. Still they waited for the final outcome of last year's agreement.

Against this background, the state Government erred in announcing a package for Gurjars by fielding local BJP lightweight Gurjar leader Ram Gopal Guard to the media on May 8. It was like waving a red rag as far as Bainsla was concerned. Ministers and BJP leaders had also

BATTLE CRY:
Gurjars block rail tracks at Karwari village in Bharatpur; (left) Kirori Singh Bainsla